# Michelle Layvant

Department of Agricultural and Resource Economics, University of California, Berkeley

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## Education

**University of California, Berkeley** 2021–present
Ph.D. Candidate in Agricultural and Resource Economics

**University of California, Berkeley** 2012–2015
B.A. in Economics, Minor in Public Policy

## Research Fields

**Primary:** Development Economics **Secondary:** Labor Economics, Behavioral Economics

## References

**Edward Miguel**
Dept. of Economics
University of California, Berkeley
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**Jeremy Magruder**
Dept. of Agricultural and Resource Economics
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**Dmitry Taubinsky**
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**Gautam Rao**
Haas School of Business & Dept. of Economics
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## Job Market Paper

**Committed to Education: School Fees, Vouchers, and the Timing of Cash Transfers**
*with Gonzalo Ferres* Available here.

**Abstract.** Primary-school dropout remains widespread in Sub-Saharan Africa, and school fees are seen as a major barrier to completion. In an experiment with 2,000 parents and children in Uganda, we study whether time inconsistency contributes to unpaid school fees and lower school participation. We first elicit parents willingness to pay for two restrictions on a cash transfer: (1) delaying it until fees are due and (2) earmarking it as a voucher paid directly to the school, holding timing fixed. Demand for both restrictions is substantial: 62 percent of parents are willing to pay for delay and 69 percent for earmarking. We then randomly assign parents to three treatment arms and a control group. The three arms provide the same amount as cash six weeks before fees are due, as cash when fees are due, or as a voucher, and the control group receives no transfer. The voucher more than doubles fees paid, increases school attendance, and cuts within-term dropout by more than half. Cash has smaller effects on all three outcomes, with no additional effect from delayed cash over early cash. Perhaps surprisingly, the vouchers effects on fee payment and attendance are largest among parents with low willingness to pay for it, in part because they substantially underestimate how much it will raise their fee payment relative to cash. In a model of quasi-hyperbolic discounting, these findings are consistent with partial naïveté, in which parents anticipate their own time inconsistency but underestimate its severity.

## Working Papers

**Impacts of Secondary School in Kenya after Two Decades**
*with Edward Miguel, Owen Ozier, and Michael Walker* Available here.

**Abstract.** This paper studies the long-run effects of access to secondary school in Kenya, where admission depended on a cutoff score on a national exam at the end of primary school. Using a regression discontinuity design and a panel that follows students for nearly two decades after the exam, the paper estimates effects on fertility, cognition, and economic outcomes. Scoring above the cutoff raises secondary school completion by 18 percentage points, with similar increases for women and men. Greater access to secondary schooling also leads to substantial and lasting improvements in cognition, with gains of 0.2-0.3 standard deviations into midlife. Realized fertility also declines substantially and persistently among men, by about 0.8 children on average, but, perhaps surprisingly, there are no detectable fertility effects among women. These fertility changes are not accompanied by changes in the probability of marriage. There is also suggestive evidence that these benefits extend to the next generation, as the children of female respondents who scored above the cutoff perform better on tests of academic skills.

## Publications

Walker, M. W., Huang, A. H., Asman, S., Baird, S. J., Fernald, L., Hamory Hicks, J., Hoces de la Guardia, F., Koiso, S., Kremer, M., Krupoff, M. N., **Layvant, M.**, Ochieng, E., Suri, P., and Miguel, E. "Intergenerational Child Mortality Impacts of Deworming: Experimental Evidence from Two Decades of the Kenya Life Panel Survey." *American Economic Journal: Applied Economics*, forthcoming.

Ma, X., **Layvant, M.**, Miguel, E., Ochieng, E., Pillarisetti, A., and Walker, M. W. "Impacts of Contemporaneous Air Pollution Exposure on Cognitive Performance in Kenya." *Journal of Health Economics*, 109:103166, 2026.

Gross, A. L., Duhon, M., Ochieng, E., Ikanga, J. N., Dow, W. H., Lee, J., Walker, M. W., **Layvant, M.**, Ngugi, A., Ehrlich, J. R., and Miguel, E. A. "Midlife Cognitive Testing in Africa: Validity of the Harmonised Cognitive Assessment Protocol in the Kenya Life Panel Survey." *BMJ Open*, 15(8), 2025.

## Grants and Fellowships

**2026**

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|---|---|
| Giannini Foundation of Agricultural Economics | $35,000 |
| Rocca Dissertation Fellowship, UC Berkeley Center for African Studies | $11,000 |
| John L. Simpson ABD Fellowship, UC Berkeley | $1,000 |

**2025**

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| Development Challenge Awards, Center for Effective Global Action (two awards) | $12,150; $12,000 |

**2024**

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|---|---|
| Learning for All, Abdul Latif Jameel Poverty Action Lab (J-PAL) | $60,768 |
| The Weiss Fund, University of Chicago | $39,498 |
| CEDA Pilot Grant, Center on the Economics and Demography of Aging | $28,400 |
| Development Challenge Award, Center for Effective Global Action | $15,000 |
| John L. Simpson ABD Fellowship, UC Berkeley | $10,000 |

**2023**

Gender Economics Research Award, UC Berkeley Economics $9,000

## Teaching

**University of California, Berkeley**

Business and Production of Beer, Wine, and Spirits 2021–23, 2025–26

Population, Environment, and Development 2024

Case Studies in Economic Development 2023

## Research Assistance

**University of California, Berkeley**

Graduate Research Assistant to Edward Miguel present

Undergraduate Research Assistant to David Card 2014–2015

**Center for Effective Global Action**

Research Assistant to Edward Miguel 2019–2022

**Partners In Health**

Pro-Bono Researcher 2016–2020

## Presentations

**UC Berkeley:** Development Lunch (2024–2026, multiple presentations), Development Workshop (2023–2026, multiple presentations), Development Department Seminar (2026), Labor Department Seminar (2026), Agricultural and Resource Economics Department Seminar (2026)

CEGA Research Retreat 2026

Economic Science Association 2026

CEGA Evidence Action Summit 2024

Population Association of America 2024

CEGA Working Group in African Political Economy 2023

CEDA Aging in Africa 2022

## Service to the Profession

Mentoring: East Africa Social Science Translation Collaborative, UC Berkeley (Spring 2023, Fall 2023)